



ON THE WRITE LINE

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MODERN BATTER DOESN'T SEEM TO TRUST HIS DEFENSIVE TECHNIQUE ANYMORE

There are more chances of a dismissal while looking to **play in a manner** that one is not used to, as was seen in the recent Sydney Test between India and Australia.

Jammu and Kashmir's splendid victory in three days over defending champions Mumbai shows how much the standard of cricket has improved in States that were earlier easy opposition for the stronger teams. Today, every team can include three outstation players, and many teams do that to strengthen their eleven. J&K has some incredibly talented players, especially in the fast bowling department, and it was their fast bowling that unsettled and tormented the Mumbai top order.

Only Shardul Thakur, batting down the order, showed the gumption and desire to stick it out. But for his batting in both innings, the Mumbai score would have been embarrassing for a side filled with four Indian Test players in their top five. What Thakur and Tanush Kotian showed with their big partnership is that with a proper mix of caution and aggression, runs could be scored on the surface. The J&K batters also showed the same attitude and thus overhauled the target quite comfortably.

The dismissal of Mumbai's Test batters once again brought to the fore the perils of the all-out aggressive mode of batting that is nowadays thought of as being central to run-making. It can work on flat pitches, but on pitches where the ball is doing something, there has to be a technique good enough to

keep out the good delivery. More crucially, there has to be the temperament to accept that a bowler can bowl the occasional maiden over, and a few dot balls don't warrant a big risky shot in response.

The modern batter doesn't seem to trust his defensive technique, consumed as he is by the thrill of hitting sixes. Nothing wrong in hitting sixes. In fact, it is exciting indeed, but in the red-ball format, the bowler has a little more help from the ball than in the white-ball version, and the six can be a risky proposition. It makes sense to single out the bowler who could be a danger and play him out, then look to score off the lesser bowlers.

There's also a weird theory that on a dicey pitch, there will be a delivery with the batter's name on it, and so it is better to thrash about than spend time defending and trying to tire out the bowlers.

Way back in the West Indies, this thought was expressed by a couple of journalists that with the lethal pace quartet that the Windies had then, it was better to counter-attack than wait for the scoreable delivery. Mohinder Amarnath, Dilip Vengsarkar, and Ravi Shastri batted in their normal unhurried manner and scored heaps of runs on that trip.

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